



Sam Mendes Interview

Read this interview by Vox to understand more about why the film was made to look like one take. <https://digit.in/may20-35>



Roger Deakins interview

Here's the Insider interview with Roger Deakins, the cinematographer of 1917. <https://digit.in/may20-36>

CAMERA WORK, CINEMATOGRAPHY, AND VFX

Techniques used in
The Lighthouse, The
Irishman and 1917

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1917

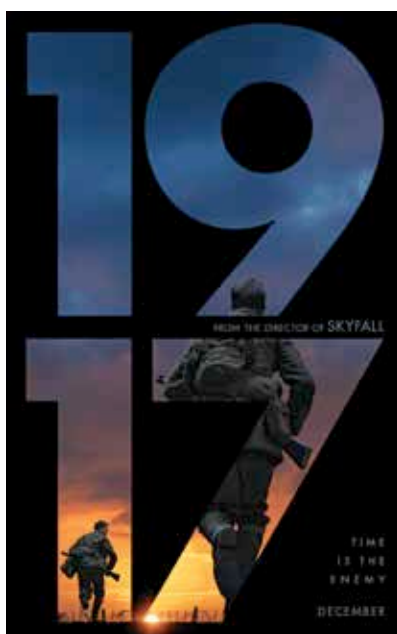
Director: Sam Mendes

Cinematographer: Roger Deakins

Directed by Sam Mendes, 1917, starring George MacKay as Schofield and Dean-Charles Chapman as Blake, is a World War I story about two British soldiers who have been assigned the seemingly impossible task of delivering an important message that will save hundreds of soldiers, including Blake's brother, who are walking into an enemy trap.

The buzz surrounding this movie is that it was shot and cut to appear as a single long continuous take. The idea for the film came from Mendes' grandfather, Alfred Hubert Mendes, who was part of World War I in the year 1917 and was a messenger on the frontlines.

Roger Deakins is the cinematographer for this movie and is best known for his work in the films No Country for Old Men, Skyfall and Blade Runner 2049. The idea behind filming 1917 as a One was to achieve an immersive experience. A one is a take which is generally longer than the usual takes in films. It involves a lot of camera movement and blocking. The blocking is where the cut takes place which is edited and synchronised to add a new take thereby making it look like one long take. Mendes wanted to pull the audience into the film and felt that the



best way to do that was to not cut away and keep the motion going, not providing an escape for the audience. From start to the end, Mendes and Deakins stalk the two actors. From bunkers to rat-infested trenches to farmhouses all the way through the enemy territory, the camera follows them continuously putting the audience in the shoes of two British soldiers.

MODELS AND PLANNING

In order to rehearse and understand the layout of the film, the Production Designer, Dennis Gassner, built scale models of every set that was going to be in the movie. The models helped the crew understand how the scene should look. In an interview with Vox, Mendes said that the crew had to measure the distance and time that every scene took. None of the sets were built until

they had measured the distance. They had to start rehearsing on plain open grounds before the trenches, farmhouses, orchards and such were built. These rehearsals included marking the journey and distance using flags and poles. In the scene where Schofield runs through the destroyed city at night, the only light source was flares. The crew had to perfectly time the moment the flares were fired since lighting and shadows were an integral part of this scene. This was tested on the models using a contraption to move around the LED lights to check for lights and shadows which would assist in good shots and hidden cuts.

FILMING

Keeping the primary instruction for the filming aspect (One) in mind, there were some rules set in place. One of the rules, as stated by an Insider interview with Deakins, was that the camera was never supposed to move backwards. Since the characters had a starting point and a fixed destination, it was supposed to keep following them forward. The solution was to move the camera 360 degrees following the characters and move forward without making a visible cut. This sort of free-flowing movement, including running and chasing the characters, required a compact, lightweight high-definition camera that was easily portable.

CAMERA

The camera used for this film was the ARRI Alexa Mini LF. In an interview with ARRI, Deakins mentioned that he prefers his cameras to be small and intimate. He prefers things to be compact.